

Minshuai Ding, Ph.D.

Bureau of Sociological Research, University of Nebraska–Lincoln

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EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Public Administration, University of Nebraska at Omaha (UNO)	2022
• Specialization: Urban Management. UNO's Local Government Management specialty was ranked #7 nationally in the 2022 <i>U.S. News & World Report</i> Best Graduate Schools rankings. • Dissertation: <i>Does Special-Purpose Government Perform Better? An Analysis of Midwest Transit Agencies</i>.	
Master of Public Administration, Rutgers University–Newark (NASPAA-accredited program)	2015
B.A. in Literature and Chinese Language, Beijing Language and Culture University	2008

ACADEMIC & RESEARCH APPOINTMENTS

Project Manager II, Bureau of Sociological Research, University of Nebraska–Lincoln	2022–Present
• Lead and manage survey-based policy research and program evaluation for state agencies, nonprofit organizations, foundations, and universities; project manager or methodological lead on 20 externally funded studies. • Full-cycle responsibility across study design, sampling, questionnaire development, multimode data collection, data quality, statistical analysis, reporting, budgets/timelines, research teams, and client/stakeholder communication. • Produced or co-produced 18 applied research and methodological reports supporting public programs in behavioral health, education, public health, agriculture, sustainability, and community research.	
Research Contributor, Center for Public Affairs Research, University of Nebraska at Omaha	2017–2019
Researcher, Transition Institute, Beijing, China	2010–2015

RESEARCH

RESEARCH INTERESTS & CURRENT AGENDA

Research interests: local governance; special-purpose government; public organizations and management; program evaluation; evidence-based governance; survey research; survey methodology.

My current research examines how institutional design shapes the capacity of public organizations to control, protect, produce, and use resources. One line of work focuses on special-purpose governments and the organizational boundaries they create within state and local governance. Using public libraries as a comparative setting, this research

examines how the allocation of administrative and fiscal control affects personnel redeployment, service continuity, and exposure to fiscal risk during periods of crisis.

A second line of research brings public administration and survey research into closer conversation by treating government surveys not simply as methodological instruments, but as part of the evidence infrastructure of government. A 50-state database built around the National Youth in Transition Database (NYTD) supports research on variation in states' capacity to produce longitudinal evidence and on the extent to which that evidence is subsequently incorporated into programmatic, budgetary, and policy decisions.

Together, these projects form a broader research agenda on institutional boundaries, organizational capacity, and the movement of resources and evidence through public organizations. This agenda provides a platform for continued research on local governance, federalism, program evaluation, and evidence-informed public decision-making, as well as opportunities for collaborative student and faculty research.

WORKING PAPERS

Ding, M. *When Evidence-Based Governance Becomes Disconnected: Evidence Production and Evidence Incorporation in U.S. State Governments*. Manuscript complete; preprint submitted to SSRN, pending posting.

Ding, M. *When Governance Boundaries Matter: Special-Purpose Government, Control Rights, and Crisis Response in U.S. Public Libraries*. Advanced manuscript.

Ding, M. *When Fiscal Boundaries Matter: Special-Purpose Governance and Downside Fiscal Risk in U.S. Public Libraries*. Advanced manuscript.

PEER-REVIEWED JOURNAL PUBLICATIONS

Olson, K., Ding, M., & Ganshert, A. (2025). The effects of Spanish-language materials in a local area ABS mixed-mode survey on response rates and sample composition: An experiment. *Survey Practice*, 19(Special Issue). <https://doi.org/10.29115/SP-2024-0019>

Ding, M. (2024). From City Hall to Twitter: Navigating political context in U.S. mayors' online engagement. *Communication and the Public*, 9(1), 114–127. <https://doi.org/10.1177/20570473231224819>

Oh, N., Ding, M., & Kim, Y. (2024). How do non-Western authoritarian countries respond to disasters? Structural difference from the pluralistic model. *International Review of Administrative Sciences*, 90(4), 845–862. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00208523241231703>

Ding, M. (2022). Mobile applications for flood emergency management in China: Functionality, usefulness and coproduction. *China Media Research*, 18(1), 38–66.

BOOK CHAPTERS

Olson, K., Ding, M., & Ganshert, A. (2026). The effects of Spanish-language materials in a local area ABS mixed-mode survey on response rates and sample composition: An experiment. In M. Sha & E. Aizpurua (Eds.), *Cross-Cultural Research in Practice* (pp. 117–134). Amazon Digital Services LLC-KDP. (Reprinted from *Survey Practice*.)

Ding, M. (2025). Turning the page: When a library becomes a special district. In R. Blair & K. Nelson (Eds.), *Managing Local Government: Cases in Effectiveness* (2nd ed.). International City/County Management Association (ICMA).

Ding, M. (2023). Mobile communication as disaster response infrastructure for cross-sector coproduction: A field study of mobile apps in China flood seasons. In M. Xie & C.-C. Chao (Eds.), *Mobile Communication in Asian Society and Culture: Continuity and Changes across Private, Organizational, and Public Spheres* (pp. 59–80). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003328896-7>

SELECTED OTHER SCHOLARLY PUBLICATIONS

Piper, R. K., & Ding, M. (2018). *Abolishing 21st century enslavement: Capitalism's pattern of labor abuse during economic shifts and restructuring (1840–present)*. Center for Public Affairs Research Report No. 416, University of Nebraska at Omaha.

Piper, R. K., & Ding, M. (2017). *A “not-so radical” urban political-economic narrative: Transforming failed liberal and conservative approaches to poverty and related social problems*. Center for Public Affairs Research Report No. 403, University of Nebraska at Omaha.

Ding, M. [as Hui Zhou]. (2019). “Efficient” China. *The Echo-Wall*, Institute of Chinese Studies, Heidelberg University. (Invited commentary.)

Ding, M. [as Hui Zhou]. (2019). When China’s long game short circuits. *The Echo-Wall*, Institute of Chinese Studies, Heidelberg University. (Invited commentary.)

SELECTED GOVERNMENT & NONPROFIT POLICY RESEARCH / PROGRAM EVALUATION

Nebraska Department of Health and Human Services — Statewide Behavioral Health Consumer Survey.

Project Manager; five consecutive annual cycles. Led study design/implementation, data processing, quality control, analysis, and methodological reporting.

Nebraska Department of Education — Indicator 14 Post-School Outcomes. Project Manager. Led federally required post-school outcome data collection and methodological reporting.

Illinois Department of Public Health — Behavioral Risk Factor Surveillance System (BRFSS). Methodological analyst/report coauthor. Evaluated frame composition and weighting effects on health survey estimates.

Nebraska Survey on Substance Use and Health. Project management and data processing for statewide behavioral-health research.

American Lung Association / Metro Omaha Tobacco Action Coalition (MOTAC). Project manager for community survey research supporting tobacco-control and public-health work.

Doane University and other educational/nonprofit partners. Program evaluation and survey research collaborations supporting organizational and educational decision-making.

University of Nebraska–Lincoln Sustainability Culture, Literacy, and Transportation Survey. Project manager for campus-wide applied survey research.

Southeast Nebraska Indigenous Awareness and Engagement Survey. Project management and data processing for community-engagement research conducted for the Center for Great Plains Studies.

Agriculture and conservation research. Project management/methodological work on Nebraska agricultural operator, grazing, soil health, conservation, and field-day surveys; provided research-methods guidance for an agricultural economics doctoral student's grazing survey project in 2025.

Doane University — DIVAS surveys. Project management for multi-year educational program evaluation and reporting.

INVITED & FEATURED TALKS

Ding, M. (2024). *Does Special-Purpose Government Perform Better? An Analysis of Midwest Transit Agencies in the U.S.* Featured presentation, 9th International Conference on Local Public Governance and Development, Tunghai University, Taiwan.

Ding, M. (2024). Research Method and Research Design. Invited research talk, Research Alliance at New York University, New York, NY, December 2024.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Ding, M., Olson, K., Meiergerd, K., Doud, R., Li, A., & Reed, J. (2025). Is shorter better? The effect of placement of informed consent information in email invitations. Poster presented at the 80th Annual Conference of the American Association for Public Opinion Research (AAPOR), St. Louis, MO.

Ding, M., Ganshert, A., & Olson, K. (2023). The effects of Spanish-language materials in a local area ABS mixed-mode survey on response rates and sample composition: An experiment. Paper presented at the Midwest Association for Public Opinion Research Annual Conference, Chicago, IL.

Ding, M. (2022). Does specialized governance of public transit make a difference in performance? An analysis of Midwest transit agencies, 2015–2019. Paper presented at the Annual Conference of the Midwest Political Science Association, Chicago, IL.

Oh, N., & Ding, M. (2022). Need for institutional isomorphism? Emergency management systems in an authoritarian country and structural differences from the pluralistic model. Paper presented at the Annual Conference of the American Society for Public Administration, Jacksonville, FL.

Ding, M. (2019). Does specialized governance of transit make a difference? An analysis of Midwest agencies. Paper presented at the Annual Conference of the Urban Affairs Association, Los Angeles, CA.

Ding, M. (2018). Administrators' perspective on fiscal sustainability of public library districts. Paper presented at the Annual Conference of the Urban Affairs Association, Toronto, Canada.

Ding, M., & Xie, M. (2018). Tweet elite in the public sphere: Analysis of Twitter use of U.S. mayors. Paper presented at the Annual Conference of the American Society for Public Administration, Denver, CO.

Piper, R. K., & Ding, M. (2018). Abolishing 21st century enslavement: Capitalism's pattern of labor abuse during economic shifts and restructuring. Paper presented at the Annual Meeting of the Society for the Study of Social Problems, Philadelphia, PA.

RESEARCH METHODS & TECHNICAL EXPERTISE

Survey methodology: probability and address-based sampling; mixed-mode data collection; questionnaire design; survey experiments; nonresponse and response-rate analysis; weighting; data quality; field operations; methodological reporting.

Quantitative/qualitative methods: regression; social network analysis; experimental design; descriptive and inferential statistics; field studies; text analysis; in-depth interview; qualitative research design.

Software/platforms: Stata; SPSS; Qualtrics (including advanced customization); WinCATI; Excel; survey data management and reporting workflows.

TEACHING & RESEARCH MENTORING

Instructor, School of Public Administration, University of Nebraska at Omaha

2018–2022

- Instructor for eight undergraduate sections across four academic years (2018–2022), with full responsibility for course design, delivery, assessment, and student support; taught face-to-face, hybrid, and online.
- Independently designed full online courses, including readings, assignments, assessments, discussion activities, and semester sequencing; also participated directly in broader online-program operations.
- PA 2170 — Introduction to Public Administration: Spring 2020 (face-to-face), 4.33/5; Fall 2020 (hybrid), evaluation did not meet the statistical reporting threshold; Spring 2022 (online), score not available.
- PA/UBNS 1010 — Introduction to Urban Studies (online): Fall 2018, 4.56/5; Spring 2019, 4.50/5; Fall 2019, 4.44/5; Spring 2021, evaluation did not meet the statistical reporting threshold; Fall 2021, 4.83/5.
- UNO Automated Course Evaluation System: average of available quantitative teaching evaluations, 4.53/5 (based on five reportable course sections).

Selected Post-Ph.D. Teaching & Research Mentoring

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| ⑩ | Research Methods Mentor for Ph.D. student, in Grazing, Soil Health and Conservation Program Survey | 2025 |
| ⑩ | Research Project, Bureau of Sociological Research, University of Nebraska–Lincoln | |
| ⑩ | Guest Speaker, Research Methods Course (Graduate), University of Maryland Baltimore County | 2024 |
| ⑩ | Invited Speaker, Research Method and Research Design, Research Alliance at New York University | 2024 |
| ⑩ | Featured Speaker, 9th International Conference on Local Public Governance and Development, Tunghai University, Taiwan | 2024 |

SERVICE, LEADERSHIP & REVIEWING

Co-Chair, College of Arts and Sciences IDEA Committee, University of Nebraska–Lincoln **Current**

- College-level collaborative leadership and committee service; contributes to institutional discussion, coordination, and program/service activities.

Founding Team Member and Contributor, Nebraska Snapshot Series, University of Nebraska–Lincoln **2024–Present**

- Public-facing social-indicator series translating survey and administrative evidence for statewide audiences.

Scholarly Reviewer

• *Communication and the Public*; *China Media Research*; *Chinese Public Administration Review*; and multiple scholarly edited volumes.

Selected nonprofit/public engagement

• Volunteer Academic Advisor, Humanities China Academy (New York), current; Executive Editor-in-Chief, Humanities China, 2023–present; Media & Public Opinion Specialist, Long Island Chinese American Association, 2015–2019.

HONORS & AWARDS

John Tarnai Memorial Scholarship Award, Association of Academic Survey Research Organizations (AASRO) **2024**

UNO Gold Medal Graduate Student, University of Nebraska at Omaha **2022**

UNO Graduate Research and Creative Activity (GRACA) Grant (\$5,000) **2019–2020**

Pi Alpha Alpha Honor Society, Rutgers University–Newark

Citation of Excellence for Enhancement of the Region and Betterment of Residents, Nassau County, New York **2016**